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Journal of Small Business & Entrepreneurship

ISSN: 0827-6331 (Print) 2169-2610 (Online) Journal homepage: http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/rsbe20

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**To cite this article:** Sushmita Guha, Paul Harrigan & Geoff Soutar (2017): Linking social media to customer relationship management (CRM): a qualitative study on SMEs, Journal of Small Business & Entrepreneurship

**To link to this article:** https://doi.org/10.1080/08276331.2017.1399628

Published online: 24 Nov 2017.

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*Journal of Small Business & Entrepreneurship*, 2017
https://doi.org/10.1080/08276331.2017.1399628

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# Linking social media to customer relationship management (CRM): a qualitative study on SMEs

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(*Received 15 February 2017; accepted 30 October 2017*)

Australian small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) owner-managers were interviewed to understand the underpinning factors of social customer relationship management (social CRM), customer engagement behaviors, and social CRM as dynamic capability. Findings show that SMEs' customers use social media to generate content, influence other customers through positive reviews, and mobilize others' actions toward the brands or products. However, SMEs tend not to use social media for making important strategic decisions or calculating CRM indicators. Key issues are around a lack of resources, data management, and privacy and control. Resource constraints force SMEs to manage their social media on a reactive and ad hoc basis. This study confirms that social CRM can be characterized as a dynamic capability in SMEs, and recommends that automated and sustained ways of collecting and integrating social data with CRM can help SMEs realize the true benefits of social CRM, and thus outweigh their resource constraints in the long term.

**Keywords:** social media; SME; CRM; social CRM; dynamic capability; Western Australia

Des propriétaires-gérants de petites et moyennes entreprises australiennes (PME) ont été interrogés afin d'améliorer la compréhension des facteurs sous-jacents à la gestion sociale de la relation client (GRC sociale), aux comportements d'engagement des clients et à la GRC sociale en tant que compétence dynamique. Les résultats révèlent que les clients des PME utilisent les réseaux sociaux pour générer du contenu, influencer d'autres clients à travers leurs critiques positives et mobiliser l'intérêt des autres clients en direction des marques ou des produits. Cependant, les PME montrent une tendance à ne pas utiliser ces mêmes réseaux sociaux pour appliquer leurs décisions stratégiques importantes ou calculer des indicateurs de GRC. Les questions clés sont centrées sur le manque de ressources, la gestion des données et la vie privée et le contrôle. Les contraintes de ressources forcent les PME à gérer leurs réseaux d'une manière réactive et ad hoc. Cette étude confirme que la GRC sociale peut être définie en tant que compétence dynamique dans les PME et avance que les processus automatisés et soutenus de collecte des données sociales et de leur intégration à la GRC peuvent aider les PME à réaliser les bénéfices réels de la GRC sociale, et de ce fait, contrebalancer leurs contraintes de ressources sur le long terme.

**Mots clés:** Réseaux sociaux; PME; GRC; GRC sociale; compétence dynamique; Australie-Occidentale

## 1. Introduction

Over the last few years, 'social CRM' has gradually evolved as a topic of interest in marketing research. Organizations are now contemplating blending social data with their

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existing CRM systems to provide tailored solutions in accordance with customer demand (VanBoskirk, Overby, and Takvorian 2011). The existing body of research on social CRM is more focused on large organizations, while our economies are dominated by small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). According to the latest ABS (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2016), there are 2,066,806 SMEs (less than 200 employees) nationwide, representing 99.8% of all Australian businesses.

This study builds on previous work by Harrigan and Miles (2014), which carried out a quantitative investigation of social CRM in SMEs in the UK. They identified a range of factors underpinning social CRM in SMEs. These were 'online community use,' 'social media support,' 'information capture,' 'information use,' 'customer relationship orientation,' 'social data use,' and 'customer communication.' The authors recommended further in-depth, qualitative exploration of these factors. We undertake such research.

This study also explores different types of customer engagement behaviors (CEBs). These are customer-contributed resources such as time, effort, skill, and knowledge that generate value for an organization (Jaakkola and Alexander 2014). There is 'augmenting' when the organization's offering is directly augmented beyond what is fundamental to the transaction, 'co-developing' when the development of organization's offering is facilitated, 'influencing' when other stakeholders' perception and preference regarding the organization is influenced, and 'mobilizing' when concrete actions from other stakeholders are induced. Jaakkola and Alexander (2014)'s research was carried out with an operator of rail services in Scotland, UK. We investigate if their findings apply in the SME context.

This study also extends research by Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013), who investigated the relationship between an organization's CRM implementation and dynamic capabilities. Dynamic capabilities theory holds that an organization combines raw resources (i.e., social media) with its routines (i.e., CRM) to build and sustain competitive advantage (Mathiassen and Vainio 2007; Wang, Hu, and Hu 2013). Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013)'s research was based on the top 1000 manufacturers and top 500 service organizations in Taiwan. We apply it to social CRM and the SME context.

Finally, we draw on the research framework proposed by Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) to position our research within the growing social media research domain. They proposed four areas of research: design and features, strategy and tactics, management and organization and measurement and value. Our investigation of social CRM, including CEBs and dynamic capabilities, spans across all of these areas.

The structure of this paper is as follows. First, we review previous pertinent literature on social media, CRM, SMEs and social CRM. Next, the approach and methodology are explained. Subsequently, the findings of the study are presented, followed by a detailed discussion section. Finally, the conclusion section summarizes the contribution of this research, and draws implications for theory and practice.

## 2. Literature review

### *2.1. Small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs)*

SMEs' contributions in the economy have led researchers, academics and practitioners to show significantly growing interest in their performance (Eid and El-Gohary 2013). Previous literatures are conclusive that SMEs face many challenges, such as institutional barriers, lack of qualified employees, low demand, lack of funds and resources which constraint their expansion and development (Doern 2009; O'Dwyer, Gilmore, and

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Carson 2009; Xu, Rohatgi, and Duan 2007). Therefore, an innovation capability is a critical attribute for SMEs to be able to differentiate themselves from their competitors and establish competitive advantage (Li and Mitchell 2009; Rosenbusch, Brinckmann, and Bausch 2011). SMEs have adopted technologies such as websites, email, and databases to innovate around product and service provision. Social media is the latest technology to offer opportunities (Askool and Nakata 2001). As social media tools are readily available and affordable, SMEs can use these tools to strengthen their customer relationships (Harrigan and Miles 2014) and use them as an opportunity to market their products or services, to communicate with customers or suppliers, and to achieve exponential growth like never before (Eid and El-Gohary 2013). When social media are combined with CRM, it leads to social CRM (social CRM) as a new strategy to manage customer relationships and build competitive advantage (Askool and Nakata 2001).

### 2.2. CRM

The term customer relationship management was originally coined in the IT domain and was mostly associated with describing systems and tools used to automate sales processes (Payne and Frow 2005). In reality, CRM is underpinned in relationship marketing and its underlying principles (Parvatiyar and Jagdish 2001). It has been referred to as 'information-enabled relationship marketing' (Ryals and Payne 2001, 3).

### 2.3. Social media marketing

Social media have caused a paradigm shift in the fundamental modes of operating all aspects of business, starting from marketing and operations to finance and human resource management (Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes 2013) and have played a transformative role in the way organizations collect and analyze consumer data to offer customized products or services according to customer's requirements (Hill, Provost, and Volinsky 2006; Aral, Muchnik, and Sundararajan 2009; Trusov, Bodapati, and Bucklin 2010). Social media are Internet-based applications, products, and tools that facilitate sharing and consumption of contents and allow users to socialize and communicate online. Currently used social media tools include publicly available platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, LinkedIn, YouTube, Snapchat, Google and also user-generated content websites such as blogs, wikis, articles, photo and video sharing and social bookmarking (Kim and Ko 2012). Social media can be used to devise innovative marketing strategies to create word-of-mouth, peer influence and behavioral contagion during product launch (Aral and Walker 2011, 2012), and to forecast future demand (Asur and Huberman 2010; Bollen, Mao, and Zeng 2011).

SMEs are now adopting social media technologies and using various social media tools as their primary marketing channel (Taneja and Toombs 2014) and establishing their online presence and brand equity at much lower cost and time commitments, as compared to traditional forms of marketing (Taneja and Toombs 2014).

### 2.4. Social CRM

As the use of social media begins to mature, the linking of social media and CRM has become increasingly important. Organizations can blend social data with existing CRM systems to provide tailored solutions to meet customer demand (VanBoskirk, Overby, and Takvorian 2011). Social CRM provides them with a two-way interactive communication channel wherein they can engage and collaborate with customers to drive value

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co-creation, product development, and conceptualization and implementation of new marketing strategies (Rodriguez, Peterson, and Krishnan 2012). Greenberg (2009, 34) suggests a definition of social CRM as:

> A philosophy and a business strategy, supported by a technology platform, business rules, workflow, processes and social characteristics, designed to engage the customer in a collaborative conversation in order to provide mutually beneficial value in a trusted and transparent business environment. It's the company's programmatic response to the customer's control of the conversation.

This defines social CRM based on the fundamentals of traditional CRM, but further augments that notion by extending it to social elements of organizational behavior and characteristics that foster interaction and communication between customers and organizations, as well as within the customer's own ecosystem (Greenberg 2009). By facilitating informative conversation and exchange of opinions with customers, social CRM enables organizations to identify, enter, and develop new market more efficiently (Warfield 2009). Thus, integrating social media tools with CRM processes offers substantial value to organizations in the form of increased sales, better communications on products and services, and effective management of customer relationship (Panagopoulos 2010). In recent times, social CRM has been researched in the context of large organizations (Rodriguez, Ajjan, and Peterson 2014; Askool and Nakata 2001) as well as SMEs (Harrigan and Miles 2014), albeit to a lesser extent. Harrigan and Miles (2014) proposed that social CRM is used to build competitive advantage in SMEs. Our research delves further in that direction.

### *2.5. Dynamic capabilities*

Dynamic capabilities theory refers to an organization's ability to conform and respond to changing market by reconstructing, reconciling and reintegrating its resources and expertise effectively (Mathiassen and Vainio 2007; Wang, Hu, and Hu 2013; Teece 2011). These activities are required if the organization is to keep up with market and technological changes (Teece 2011). Dynamic capabilities theory builds on the resource-based view (RBV) of the organization which identifies internal resources of organizations as the most vital factor for growth and superior performance (Harrigan and Miles 2014). While the RBV emphasizes the importance of possession and deployment of such unique resources, dynamic capabilities theory extends it to bring in the importance of reconfiguring and redeploying these resources in response to a changing environment (Doving and Gooderham 2008; Teece 2011), making these resources a foundation for developing higher order capabilities (Ravichandran and Lertwongsatien 2005). However, developing such capabilities requires organizations to devise appropriate strategies and business processes that can utilize and consume these resources into building new competencies (Doving and Gooderham 2008). Social media is one such resource that can be utilized by strategic organizational processes such as CRM (Tan, Yen, and Fang 2002). This is very relevant in the context of SMEs, as customer relationships are often a core differentiator between SMEs and larger organizations. If SMEs combine social media and CRM, they may well be developing higher order dynamic capabilities (Harrigan and Miles 2014).

## 3. Research questions

This study builds on four previous pieces of research. The key findings of these studies are shown in Table 1.

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Table 1. Key findings from previous research.

| Authors | Key findings |
|---|---|
| Harrigan and Miles (2014) | Harrigan and Miles (2014) uncovered seven complementary yet distinctive factors that underpinned SMEs' social CRM activities through quantitative investigation in the UK. These were 'online community use,' 'social media support,' 'information capture,' 'information use,' 'customer relationship orientation,' 'social data use' and 'customer communication.' An online survey was completed by 156 SMEs.<br>In addition to establishing the underpinning factors, their findings highlighted following areas in particular:<br>– importance of a customer relationship orientation<br>– support and data issues around social media use<br>– importance of customer engagement in online communities<br>– driving role of information processes.<br>Harrigan and Miles (2014) characterized social CRM as dynamic capabilities in SMEs and suggested that SME owner-managers need to strategically combine social media use with their CRM activities. |
| Jaakola and Alexander (2014) | Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) identified and defined four different types of customer engagement behaviors (CEB) which are 'augmenting behavior,' 'co-developing behavior,' 'influencing behavior,' and 'mobilizing behavior,' carried out with an operator of rail services in Scotland, UK. They adopted an embedded case study approach.<br>Their study focused on a multi-stakeholder service system and emphasized on the role of CEB in value co creation within the same. They amalgamated the theoretical perspectives of CE and value co-creation with the analysis of a rich case study of a public transport service system involving consumers, communities, businesses, and governmental organizations.<br>Their findings recommended the followings:<br>– organizations should focus more on the resources that customers can contribute.<br>– organizations should explore the potential to engage diverse stakeholders around a common cause.<br>– organizations should employ organically emerging systems that provide opportunities for more extensive value co-creation. |
| Wang et al. (2013) | Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013)'s work was based on the top 1000 manufacturers and top 500 service organizations in Taiwan and investigated the relationship between an organization's CRM implementation and dynamic capabilities. Their results showed important direct effects of an organization's market orientation, use of IT to support CRM, and the functionality of IT infrastructure capabilities on its dynamic marketing capabilities. |
| Aral et al. (2013) | Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) proposed a framework to stimulate research on the transformative impacts of social media across four areas: design and features, strategy and tactics, management and organization and measurement and value. They outlined a broad research agenda for understanding the relationships among social media, business, and society. |

Research by Harrigan and Miles (2014) uncovered seven complementary yet distinctive factors that underpinned SMEs' social CRM activities through quantitative investigation in the UK. However, the identified factors require further qualitative investigation, to provide in-depth understanding for theory and practice. Second, based on the studied

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cases where a range of CEBs were evident, Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) identified and defined four different types of CEBs which are augmenting behavior, co-developing behavior, influencing behavior, and mobilizing behavior. This study extends these findings to social CRM in SMEs, and investigates how these CEBs exist there. Third, Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013) looked at organizations' dynamic capabilities and their association with CRM processes. This study extends these findings to social CRM, and the SME context; in particular, it delves into dynamic marketing capabilities/market orientation, social media support, and IT infrastructure capabilities, from the previous research.

Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) proposed a framework to stimulate research on the transformative impacts of social media across many disciplines. They outlined a number of broad concepts and strategic drivers that could be applied to many emerging areas of research, with their proposed framework providing an initial roadmap to guide these endeavors. Social CRM in SMEs is one such emerging research area, which can leverage on the framework and guidelines provided by Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) for a better research outcome. Table 2 outlines how.

The specific research objectives of this study are:

- What is the range of factors underpinning SMEs' social CRM activities?
- What types of CEBs do social CRM enable for SMEs?
- Should social CRM be characterized as a dynamic capability in SMEs?

## 4. Research methodology

This study adopts a qualitative research method, through in-depth interviews with SME owner-managers based in Perth, Western Australia (WA). This approach is suitable for unexplored populations (Morrow and Smith 2000), which SMEs tend to be. As this study validates and explores previous research on a range of underpinning factors, CEBs, and IT capabilities in SMEs, a qualitative approach is ideal to uncover in-depth insights (Butler and Hansen 1991). According to Curran and Blackburn (1994), semi-structured face-to-face interview is one of the most effective strategies for collecting data from SMEs' owner-managers. We use this in this study.

### *4.1. Sample characteristics*

SMEs were sampled across various industry sectors based on two criteria: number of employees ranging from 1 to 199 and use of social media to some extent. Eight SMEs were randomly selected from Spacecubed (www.spacecubed.com). Spacecubed is a co-working and collaborative space for SMEs. SME owner-managers, as dominant figures in their organizations, were specifically chosen as the interviewees (Table 3).

An invitation email was sent out to potential respondents to inform them about the nature of the study and the intended use of the data. Interviews were arranged through a combination of email, telephone and social media communications. With prior consent from the interviewees, the interviews were audio-recorded using a digital recorder, transcribed by the researchers, and securely stored along with the transcriptions.

### *4.2. Interview design*

Interviews were designed to be semi-structured. Semi-structured interviews 'are a useful form of data collection that allow you to explore the perspectives and perceptions of

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Table 2. Framework for social media research in SMEs. Adapted from Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013).

| | Activities | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Levels of analysis | Design and features | Strategy and tactics | Management and organization | Measurement and value |
| Small and medium business | How SMEs should interact with specific platform features to maximize their benefits? What features should SMEs design into their home-grown social media initiatives? | What types of social media initiatives works best for what SMES? How SMEs should interact with public social media? What combinations of home-grown and public social media initiatives SMEs should peruse? How SMEs should respond to social media crisis? | How SMEs should organize, govern, fund and evolve their social media capabilities? What skills and culture changes are needed to best adapt to a social world? Which skills, talent or human resources SMEs should develop? How SMEs should create incentives to guide social media activities? | How do we measure the short- and long-term bottom line and immediate outcomes of social media for SMEs? How social media add value to SMEs? What industry-wise efficiencies have been (can be) attained by social media? |

Table 3. Profile of respondents.

| SMEs | No. of employees | Company profile | Nature of business | Founding year | Interviewee | Current position |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SME 1 | 9 | Marketing agency | B2B, National, International | 2005 | Respondent 1 | Owner |
| SME 2 | 12 | 1. Technical writing services<br>2. Healthcare communications | B2B, B2C | 2010 | Respondent 2 | Owner |
| SME 3 | 1 | 1. Business newspaper<br>2. Business academy | B2B, Local | 2010 | Respondent 3 | Owner |
| SME 4 | 1 | Customized technical writing | B2B, Local | 2015 | Respondent 4 | Owner |
| SME 5 | 14 | Manufacturer and retailer of bicycles | B2B, B2C National | 2014 | Respondent 5 | Owner-manager |
| SME 6 | 19, 4 | 1. Franchisee outlet<br>2. E-commerce-based software solution | B2B, B2C National | 2013 | Respondent 6 | Co-founder |
| SME 7 | 21 | Management consultancy | B2B, National | 2003 | Respondent 7 | Owner |
| SME 8 | 4 | Educational academy | B2B, National | 2015 | Respondent 8 | Owner |

various stakeholders' (Daymon and Holloway 2002, 166) and characterize participants' perspectives and experiences in great depth to enable in-depth understanding.

The interviews would commence with general questions about participant's personal information (gender, age, educational qualifications), and information about the organization (size, growth phase, number of employees, the use of social media as a marketing tool, how frequently they use it, etc.) and gradually progress towards a more elaborate discussion. The interview questions incorporated the themes identified from previous research (Harrigan and Miles 2014; Jaakkola and Alexander 2014; Wang, Hu, and Hu 2013). The duration of the interviews was approximately 45–60 min. Table 4 provides more detail.

### *4.3. Data analysis*

The basic analytical strategy used in this study was coding. Key excerpts of text from interviews were selected and highlighted in different colors representing the themes. An inductive approach to coding was taken in order to 'avoid rigidity and premature closure that are risks of a deductive approach' (Lapadat 2010, 926). Finally, validity and reliability were ensured through various methods such as prolonged engagement with and persistent observation of the sample population, leaving an audit trail, peer debriefing, weighting the evidence, and rich and thick description (Onwuegbuzie and Leech 2007).

## 5. Findings

The key findings, supported by quotes from the interview transcripts, are presented.

### *5.1. Factors underpinning social CRM*

#### *5.1.1. Online community use*

'Online community use' describes several aspects of managing online customer communities by SMEs. The most prevalent use cases of online communities include customer engagement and creating awareness. While most of the SMEs treat these platforms as information portal or broadcasting media, and not so much for creating tangible impact on the bottom line, some SMEs do appreciate the strategic significance (for example, strengthening the brand) too. These points are illustrated as follows:

> We use it for us as well as our clients communicating to a broader audience to demonstrate what we're good at. (R1)
>
> These platforms are just for information; we don't get any business out of that. (R8)
>
> At one point in time, for months together, we tried with social media, spent some amount of money. It doesn't guarantee a lot of traction on sales growth. (R6)
>
> Social media is to let our customers know what's new. It's like broadcasting tool for us. (R8)
>
> Online communities provide a variety of different communication platforms for different reasons in using different language and visuals to create a brand personality about our business… they are quite important especially for our healthcare communications because we do targeted posts and it's used to let our online communities be aware of what we're doing. (R2)

One of the respondents mentions that they are exploring the use of online communities as a platform 'to drive traffic, to increase engagement in communities, to create

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Table 4. Themes, sources, and example items.

| Themes | Sources | Example questions |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Online community use | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | Do you use online communities as part of your marketing strategy?<br>What type of online communities do you use and how central or important it is in your overall marketing strategy? Can you explain a little on that? |
| 2. Social media support | Harrigan and Miles (2014); Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013) | Does social media enable your CRM systems/processes to support your sales and marketing activities? Can you expand on that or give few examples to support this?<br>Do you use social media to enable your CRM systems/processes in helping your sales force? |
| 3. Information capture | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | How do you capture and manage customer information?<br>How do you collect customer information? Do you use social media for this purpose? What is the frequency? Is it an ongoing process? |
| 4. Information use | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | Do you use customer information to measure and analyze CRM indicators such as customer lifetime value, customer-to-customer referral value and inter-customer information sharing? |
| 5. Customer relationship orientation | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | What comes to your mind when you think of customer relationships?<br>Are customer relationships considered to be a valuable asset in your organization? |
| 6. Social data use | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | Do you collect external data (for example, competitor information) from social media?<br>Do you use social media to collect data for your CRM systems/processes? Explain |
| 7. Customer communication | Harrigan and Miles (2014) | Do you enable your customers to have interactive communications with you? How? Give example.<br>How do you manage customer communication in your organization? Explain |
| 8. Engagement (augmenting, co-developing, influencing, mobilizing) | Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) | *Augmenting behavior*<br>Do your customers actively engage with other existing and potential customers to sell your products/services? Can you expand little on that?<br>*Co-developing behavior*<br>Do you use social media to involve your customer for giving ideas for new products or services, improvement ideas, or other feedback?<br>*Influencing behavior*<br>Do your customers actively advocate for your products/services on social media platforms?<br>*Mobilizing behavior*<br>Do your customers actively promote your brand on social media platforms? |
| 9. Dynamic marketing capabilities/market orientation | Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013) | Do you do a lot of in-house market research in your organization?<br>How quickly can you detect changes in industry (for example, technology, regulations, etc.) or customer preferences, and respond to it accordingly? |
| 10. IT infrastructure capability | Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013) | Do you have IT capability in developing, managing, or maintaining organization-wide or business unit-specific applications and infrastructures such as:<br>• management information systems, decision support systems, disaster recovery planning, business recovery services.<br>• electronic linkages to suppliers or customers. |

awareness, to promote events, to inform and educate public and groups' (R3). They involve customers in product development by taking their feedback through a couple of closed groups in social media where they 'test advertisement, product etc., get feedback, and then make changes accordingly" (R3).

SMEs have diverse views on how they go about managing the online communities. Being at the early stage of start-up, most of the respondents are still in the experimental phase to see which social media platforms work best for their business. Some of them are yet to have adequate contents to drive interactions. One of the SMEs has employees who manage total marketing activities including social media. The following quotes illustrate these situations:

> We're still in the phase of testing to see which one works best, it's just sort of in an experimental stage. (R3)

> I don't think I've got enough content yet for interaction. One of my clients wants me to produce videos on how to do things in Word, PowerPoint, Excel etc. Once I get those contents ready, I can then start interaction in social media. So that's the long-term plan. (R5)

> .. We do have couple of staff who are full time marketing employees. (R7)

### *5.1.2. Social media support*

'Social media support' emphasizes how social media drive CRM operations and decisions. Some of the respondents do not connect social media data with CRM processes. One of the respondents states that, 'we use social media for B2C sales, and CRM for B2B; we don't cross the two. Many of our B2B customers don't even have emails and no one is there on social media - so they are two completely different markets' (R5). Another respondent indicates that they, being a young start-up, are yet to 'create the environment in order to collect that information from social media and use it for CRM' (R2). The other respondents do collect and process the social media data and feed it into their CRM process; but the process is largely manual. The following quotes exemplify these points:

> All the research we do to get data to feed our CRM systems comes from social media like LinkedIn. But that is not done automatically, but done through in-house process. (R7)

> We have a checklist to ensure that when we send out a newsletter, our CRM is linked to it and other social media platforms are linked to it as well, but not in one package and not automated, because that would cost money and we are not yet at that level. (R1)

The respondents who use social data to drive CRM activities agree that social data support their marketing activities. Some of the respondents use social data for customizing communication. The following quotes illustrate this point:

> We rely on free word-of-mouth marketing in social media for our B2C sales. (R5)

> We use social media for marketing our activities. (R2)

> The same content can be tweaked in different ways on Facebook, Instagram, or Linked-in. How you share it and what we say need to be appropriate for that medium and how that medium may be used. (R1)

Most of the SMEs confirm that social media can be used to enhance customer trust and loyalty. This is illustrated as follows:

> If there are people giving positive feedback, it must be helping. Because word of mouth is spreading. (R8)

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> ……. .I think once you become the person who is getting recommended, then getting testimonials etc. become so much value and important part of it. So yes, definitely. (R4)
>
> Being a retail business we do a lot of work with local community grown non-profit groups, and if we publish it through social media it creates a level of trust in the people who follow us in the community. (R6)

### *5.1.3. Information capture*

'Information capture' elaborates on how SMEs are collecting customer information from various sources. SMEs collect customer information mostly through websites, business cards, subscriptions through their social media platforms, videos from social media platform (such as YouTube), emails, enquiry or feedback forms, events, newsletter sign-ups, etc. This is illustrated as follows:

> We use email platforms, link on web, and browser. Yes, we rely on social media for my event and promotions and of course email marketing. (R3)
>
> Our website, networking, business cards that we collect when we do networking, tracking newsletter, subscription through our social media platforms, search engine optimization through our website and content management. We do use YouTube as well. (R1)

A few respondents clarified that collecting customer information is more dependent on personal networking or developing relationships face to face with their customers than on social media. This is illustrated as follows:

> We develop customer information database, and that strategy is not related to social media. We actually have big focus in developing relationship with customers through conversation, interviews, catch-ups etc., which result in generating customer information. (R7)
>
> In retail business, this is chaotic and more of a spread sheet-based process. Some customers are open about their personal information like name phone number email, some are not. Whenever we get it through conversation with them, we keep it in our database. (R6)

When it comes to integrating customer information from various sources into CRM system, the findings observe a diverse range of opinions in SMEs. Some SMEs successfully manage this process in a sustained way. This is illustrated as follows:

> We have got an internal system, we have got a CRM. So, everything goes there. For example, on Facebook page we review who is visiting, who is replying and what's the age group and how many kids do they have. (R8)
>
> Yes, we integrate and merge it of course to get the understanding the person and his needs. (R3)
>
> It's an ongoing process. For software business, it is an automated process. For the other one it's a manual thing – it's a sustained initiative. (R6)

However, some SMEs, being small and budget-constrained, can't dedicate resources to carry out this process. This is illustrated as follows:

> …… ..we'd like to have the resource, that are dedicated staff to do that but that would be a significant cost for a small business to manage. (R1)
>
> Being a small business, I don't have the resources to do it on a regular basis. (R2)

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### *5.1.4. Information use*

'Information use' explores how SMEs leverage social CRM-generated information in making important strategic decisions, and calculating key CRM indicators like customer life time value, customer-to-customer referral value or inter-customer information. Some SMEs do not even analyze these key CRM indicators, as evident in one respondent's comment; 'We don't measure these indicators, but keep an eye on what's happening in the market' (R8). Another respondent concurs by saying that they 'don't actually track the customer-to-customer referral value as a database or as a tracker' (R6). However, some of the respondents mention that they do capture these indicators but might not analyze it in detail, or they do it but not by using their social CRM systems. The following quotes evidence these points:

> We do it more through our PNL (Profit and Loss account) than in CRM system so we know how long a customer has been with us, and what value we get from our goods sold to them. (R1)
>
> Yes, we do capture these indicators but we haven't actually measured or analyzed them because we don't have a tool to do that. (R8)

However, a small number of respondents indicate that they do find social data useful for analyzing these CRM indicators. This is illustrated as follows:

> Somebody showed how to use insight which is very helpful. I will try to see who would likely be my long-term clients. …I will target more such businesses. (R4)
>
> If you look into analytics and go into further, you track everything then. It's easier to work out retention rate. (R3)

### *5.1.5. Customer relationship orientation*

'Customer relationship orientation' describes the extent of cultural orientation in SMEs towards maintaining long-term customer relationships. All respondents understand, appreciate and practice a customer-oriented culture, as evident in a respondent's comment: 'We consider customer as the most valuables asset. You have the business because you have the customers' (R6). Senior management in all SMEs emphasizes the importance of customer relationships and promotes a culture that fosters building and maintaining long-lasting customer relationships. A few quotes below illustrate this.

> Our business is built on the relationships we build with the customers. We have handful number of clients, and we manage each one of them very carefully and directly. (R7)
>
> Customer relationship is very big for me. Most of my ongoing marketing will be by word of mouth. So building customer relationship will be really important. (R4)

One respondent mentions that social media is important in building customer relationships: 'for managing customer relation in our B2C side of the business, we are trying very hard to align ourselves with potential customers - their beliefs and values. Social media would definitely be the way I want to think of that' (R5).

### *5.1.6. Social data use*

'Social data use' describes the customer data types that SMEs capture from social media. SMEs do a lot of research on their competitors on social media platform and collect

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necessary information. SMEs having no real competition collect information about the companies who have somewhat similar products or services offerings as they have. These points are illustrated with the following quotes:

> We Google our competition and see what they are putting up on Facebook or social media or office blog, what promotions they are running, and so on. (R2)

> We do research on competitors (what's happiness to them), even though not in a very sustained way. (R6)

> We definitely collect data from organizations that are somewhat similar to us. (R5)

However, one of the respondents highlights that they find it challenging to identify and extract data from social media: 'the information provided by social media is not very clear, the reason being that you can't get too much into Facebook to grab information. There might be restrictions applied on the information you ask' (R3).

#### *5.1.7. Customer communication*

'Customer communication' describes the customer communication norms of SMEs. SMEs still largely depend on traditional ways of communications like phone, emails, newsletter, face-to-face meetings, etc. Some of them perceive social media platforms being too open for conducting interactive discussions with customers. This is illustrated with the following quotes:

> We communicate with our customers according to what suits them best; so I'd say phone, e-mail, and newsletter. I'd put social media down the end because the way we work with it is it's an added bonus, a nice tool to create personality but not as driver. (R1)

> We rely heavily on email (around 95 percent), and to a very small extent, social media (around 5 percent), for communications to our customers. (R4)

> One of the disadvantages of social media is probably that it's too open, so you can't really have a private type of conversation. (R6)

However, some of the respondents are now leveraging the interactive nature of social media for conducting two-way communications with their customers. They address the aforesaid challenge of openness in social media platforms by restricting the discussions to closed groups or directly at personal level. The following quotes illustrate this trend:

> We have these closed groups where there are several small business customers and we can interact with them, track conversations, and test our promotions. (R3)

> Yes, we interact with our customers in social media, but in personal level. We touch base directly. (R7)

### *5.2. Customer engagement behaviors (CEB) enabled by social CRM*

Customer engagement can be defined as engagement between a company/brand and its customers. Findings with respect to the four types of CEBs identified by Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) are highlighted below.

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### *5.2.1. Augmenting behaviors*

SMEs are identifying the benefits of using social media as a platform for customer engagement. Social media has become a medium to share and promote their achievements. SMEs get referred by their satisfied customers on these online portals. Below are a few quotes from the respondents supporting these points:

> When we do good work and we share on social media programs, invariably our customers will share within their own networks as well. (R1)

> Yes, definitely. That's a large part of how we get the attention; it is led by people who might not even be customers but they might just be supporters and they spread the word of what we're doing, on social media. (R5)

> Yes in the retail business that happens quite often. Suppose you put some sort of promotional offer on a page, so people share it or tag it to some friends. So it becomes a referral. (R6)

A few of the respondents indicate that their customers generate contents about their company or products or services in social media, for example, posting in their Facebook page, or writing articles in their corporate blog, etc.; these contents are verified by SME owners before they get published.

> We get customers to write to write our content, that they send us to be put up on our website and that then goes to social media - as an educational source, but not as advertising source. (R3)

> Lots of the stuff that I learnt over the last few months is about building some affiliate relationship as you are not the only one selling your products. (R4)

> They need to get in touch with me first. Nothing gets published unless I've seen it or I've rated it. (R2)

### *5.2.2. Co-developing behavior*

Even though some SMEs use social media to involve their customers for new or improvement ideas or other feedback, generally, this trend is not prevalent in SMEs. This point is illustrated with the following quotes:

> I have done it in some other communities that I belong to, I have done polls etc., I just wanted to gauge who does what etc. Once I have my own group may be I will mastermind that some time, and do on my website and stuff as well. (R4)

> We appreciate people coming and chatting with us. And thank them whenever they communicate whether it is positive or negative, it doesn't matter. However beyond that we don't enable anyone to communicate. (R6)

Therefore, this particular CEB type is not facilitated well at the moment by social CRM in SMEs, specifically in start-up organizations, as further supported by the following quote:

> No. At this early stage of development, we don't really go to social media maybe mainly because it could be detrimental, it could be quite a dangerous thing to just randomly ask a whole bunch of people for guidance. Then you get all sorts of that and they send you in every direction possible. It's not helpful at all. (R5)

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#### *5.2.3. Influencing behavior*

Some SMEs are still hesitant to unlock the review or feedback features in their social media forums. One respondent states, 'I haven't turned on my review aspect on FB yet and not sure if I will. I have heard it has negative impacts, people have nasty experiences and it takes long time to sort that out' (R4). However, the SMEs who do enable feedback and reviews in social media appreciate that these can be very effective mechanisms to bring in more business which is apparent from the following quotes:

> We have people who have been referred to by existing customers, or read our blog, so it attracts more potential customers. (R6)

> ……. word-of-mouth, yes. Quite a bit. A lot of my clients come through word-of-mouth on social media. (R2)

#### *5.2.4. Mobilizing behavior*

Findings support that SMEs are benefited by customers promoting their products on social media. One respondent mentions that 'you do strategies based on your situation but there is element of hope that the customer is going to come back when she get best service.' This contributes in mobilizing other stakeholders' actions towards their brand or products. But being an SME with resource constraints, managing it is not always easy, as one respondent points out:

> No there is no real monitoring. It is real hard to keep track of everything - when they share etc. Because people in the community love what we do, they always look out for us. So if there was anything negative, they would normally tag us in to notify that there is something wrong and we then go ahead and address the issue. (R1)

### ***5.3. Social CRM as a dynamic capability***

#### *5.3.1. Dynamic marketing capabilities and market orientation*

SMEs generally confirm that they involve their cross-functional teams in carrying out their core marketing process. A few illustrations are as follows:

> Our marketers develop the plan, and we work with our other co-services to make it all happen. (R1)

> We have me, we have a person on my team who is a market research person, we have a business processes person and we have a medical person who gives overall view. So that is a cross-functional team. (R2)

SMEs do integrate key information from related industries in carrying out their co-marketing processes. They keep track on new innovation, curriculum, current trends as well as competitor's pricing and strategies. Supporting quotes for the above-mentioned facts are as follows:

> We keep an eye on Australian curriculum, we interact with school teachers, so yes we do. (R8)

> Yes, we consider competitor's pricing and strategies in taking any decision related to new innovation or innovative features or products or services or pricing. (R6)

> We use current trends and demographic information or research information depending on the campaign. (Respondent 1)

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Regarding market orientation, SMEs do in-house market research, although to small extent, as well as competitor analysis. This is illustrated as follows:

> Do some market research but not a lot because for small start-up it needs money. So we do it ourselves Google directly. (R6)

> I wouldn't say a lot but all the market research we do is in-house. And that's mainly around product development made-ups. (R5)

> We do competitor analysis, we do mystery shopping, we do web research, and we do surveys. (R1)

SMEs generally agree that they have to keep track of the changes in the industry to maintain their quality improvement. Information regarding these changes are either updated online or sent out to the concerned customers. This is evident in the following responses:

> We have to do it in the medical industry. With the health department and medicine in Australia, AMA and things change quite quickly in quality improvement. We have to send message to our clients to get their websites up-to-date. (R2)

> As soon as I'm aware of any change and I have studied it and I know what the implications are going to be, we inform our clients. (R2)

One of the respondents indicates that the change in their industry is very slow: 'customer trends in the bicycle industry change very slowly. And we can often see trends coming from a mile away and so it's quite easy to be one year ahead of the curve because the trends move so slowly' (R5).

### *5.3.2. Social media support*

The findings discussed already in Section 5.1.2, under 'social media support,' apply here as well, and hence omitted from this section to avoid repetition.

### *5.3.3. IT infrastructure capability*

IT infrastructure capabilities represent the IT resources supporting organization's operation. While some of the respondents support complex transactions and share information regarding that through social media and CRM, others do it to a very limited extent, for example, basic information sharing through email. Quotes illustrating this point are given below:

> Our CRM is now actually investigating on having a portal reclaim which can now look at everything that we have done for our customers. (R1)

> Next year would be 3, in IT capability ranking scale. Long term would be 4. I would love technology where I can put up products and customers can simply go and grab it. At the moment I will have to use something like Dropbox. (R5)

> We use mostly emails and phone calls for sharing information. (R5)

According to a few SMEs, they have existing IT capabilities in management information system, decision support system, messaging services such as emails, and large-scale

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data processing. Other SMEs are still working on these, and have plans in future to develop these IT capabilities.

> We are doing business process improvement. MIS and decision support system is a part of our tool that includes in our capability. (R7)

> … .it would just be email at this point. But we're working on the CRM backend system but not with the suppliers. (R2)

> In retail business we do have a point of sale system which obviously comes with all the data processing and business reporting capabilities. (R6)

## 6. Discussion

This study closely examines the factors underpinning social CRM, CEBs enabled by social CRM, and social CRM as a dynamic capability in SMEs.

### *6.1. Factors underpinning social CRM*

Findings generally confirm all the seven critical factors underpinning social CRM in SMEs, as identified by Harrigan and Miles (2014). In addition, they reveal a number of significant insights. Social media, specifically online communities, are critical for SMEs. Our findings show that SMEs tend to use online communities for customer engagement and creating awareness, but that these platforms rarely create tangible impact on sales or revenue growth. Some previous research has also found this to be the case (Harrigan and Miles 2014; O'Cass and Weerawardena 2009). Findings also suggest that SMEs are now utilizing online communities for enhancing customer loyalty and trust. Some challenges for SMEs and their customers are maintaining control and lack of privacy (Nakara, Benmoussa, and Jaouen 2012). With regard to the data created by online communities, SMEs tend to manage this manually, rather than it being automatically integrated with other customer data. Previous research has found process automation to be lacking in SMEs, due to challenges around technical expertise and resources (Carson et al. 1995; Doern 2009; Eid and El-Gohary 2013). We also find that SMEs tend not to rely on social media data for strategic marketing decisions. This is in line with previous research, which has suggested that social media data is excluded from marketing decision-making due to the complexity involved in quantifying and analyzing it (Bijmolt et al. 2010; Sandberg 2014).

### *6.2. Customer engagement behavior (CEB) enabled by social CRM*

This study explores the CEBs as identified by Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) and generally confirms that all the CEBs apply to the SME context, except one. Findings suggest that social media facilitates customer-generated content such as posting on a Facebook page, or writing articles for blogs. These are 'augmenting behaviors' (Jaakkola and Alexander 2014; Schau, Albert, and Eric 2009). Previous research has also suggested that organizations can customize their products or services by involving customer's feedback (Grönroos and Annika 2011; Hoyer et al. 2010); that is, promoting 'co-developing behaviors.' However, we do not find this to be the case in the SME context. A possible reason could be the nascent, start-up nature of our sample. We find that SMEs' customers are blogging about products or services and giving positive reviews

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and comments on social media. This reflects 'influencing behavior,' and extends previous research on word-of-mouth and recommendations (Bansal and Peter 2000; Dholakia et al. 2009). Findings also suggest that SMEs benefit from customers promoting their products on social media, which mobilizes other stakeholders to take action towards their brand or products. This is a 'mobilizing behavior.'

### *6.3. Social CRM as a dynamic capability*

Findings suggest that SMEs identify industry change and track competition in order to maintain their market position. This corroborates previous research (for example, Chen, Chiang, and Storey 2012; Harrigan and Miles 2014). This environmental scanning leads them to adopt and adapt social media technologies (as resources) to fit with existing organizational routines, specifically CRM (Wang, Hu, and Hu 2013). The results suggested that social media enabled CRM and marketing orientation is evident in SMEs that we conclude are characteristic of dynamic capabilities (Banker et al. 2006; Harrigan and Miles 2014).

### *6.4. Examining the level of social CRM integration in SMEs*

This study analyzes the level of social CRM integration in SMEs with respect to four areas of the research framework as proposed by Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013). With regard to the 'design and features' area, findings show that SMEs tend to use social media features for information sharing and broadcasting only, and not so much for interactive purposes due to privacy concerns. Some previous research has also found this to be the case (Harrigan Miles 2014; Kumar et al. 2010). With regard to 'strategy and tactics,' findings suggest that SMEs tend not to utilize social media for making important strategic decisions and calculating CRM indicators, as highlighted in previous research (Bijmolt et al. 2010; Sandberg 2014; Kumar et al. 2010). Some previous research has found resource constraints as one of the primary challenges facing SMEs (Doern 2009; O'Dwyer, Gilmore, and Carson 2009; Xu, Rohatgi, and Duan 2007). We find that resource constraints cause SMEs to adopt an ad hoc and reactive approach towards 'management and organization' of their social media. With respect to 'measurement and value,' SMEs generally acknowledge the role of social media in increased customer engagement, brand awareness, trust and loyalty (O'Cass and Weerawardena 2009; O'Dwyer, Gilmore, and Carson 2009).

## 7. Conclusion

This study closely examines the social CRM strategies and implications in SMEs. Through a qualitative exploration, it generally confirms all the seven critical factors underpinning social CRM in SMEs as identified by Harrigan and Miles (2014), and further provides a number of new insights. It explores the CEBs as identified by Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) in the context of social CRM in SMEs and concludes that all the CEBs are facilitated by SMEs, except the 'co-developing behavior.' Drawing on the research by Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013), this study establishes that social CRM can be characterized as a dynamic capability in SMEs. Finally, a research framework proposed by Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) is used to guide the study across four areas: design and features, strategy and tactics, management and organization, and measurement and value.

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### 7.1. Theoretical implications

We extend Harrigan and Miles' (2014) research around social CRM in SMEs. We build on their quantitative work by undertaking a qualitative study to provide in-depth understanding of the range of factors underpinning social CRM in SMEs. Key issues to emerge are around customer engagement, data management, and privacy and control. We extend Jaakkola and Alexander's (2014) research around CEBs. SMEs' customers do tend to use social media to engage in a range of behaviors around the brand, but co-developing behaviors seem to be lacking. These relate to product, service, and value co-creation. We extend Wang, Hu, and Hu (2013)'s research to assert that dynamic capabilities theory is an appropriate lens through which to view social CRM in SMEs. Finally, we use the holistic framework proposed by Aral, Dellarocas, and Godes (2013) to guide and position social media research. We have investigated the design and features, strategy and tactics, management and organization, and measurement and value of social CRM in SMEs.

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### 7.2. Managerial implications

SMEs should not view social media as a channel to broadcast advertising messages or information. They should exploit the interactive features of social media to generate valuable customer reviews and feedback on products, services, new offerings, and promotional campaigns. They generally tend to avoid this due to privacy concerns, which can be mitigated by using controlled and secure private forums, such as Facebook closed groups, or one-on-one conversations, such as Facebook messenger. SMEs should also craft customized communications, by using different formats, languages, and visuals for different platforms targeting different customer segments, to create more impact and achieve better brand recognition. SMEs should explore automated and sustained ways of collecting social data, and integrating it with CRM systems and processes. This will help them realize the true benefit of social CRM capabilities, which will outweigh their resource constraints in the long term. Finally, SMEs should explore the analytic tools and insight reports that are freely available in many social media platforms, to calculate CRM indicators such as customer retention rate.

The fact that this study adopted a qualitative approach using a small sample of Australian SMEs limits the generalizability of the results. Future research could explore a larger sample size, from more diverse geographical locations. Future research could also investigate the issues uncovered in this study in a sample of more established SMEs.

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